

Second Coming Bodily

doc-second-coming-bodily
Eschatology · Return of Christ · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.963
confidence high

Statement under examination

Jesus Christ will return personally, visibly, audibly, and bodily in a yet-future event to judge the living and the dead, not as a past event already fulfilled in AD 70 nor as an exclusively spiritual reality without bodily appearing.

In plain language

The return texts use a tight cluster of words that point one direction. In Acts 1:11 the angels say this same Jesus will come, *eleusetai*, a future verb, in the same manner, *hon tropon*, that the disciples watched him go into heaven. The watching verb is *ethesasthe* from *theaomai*, the same eyewitness verb John uses for we beheld his glory and which we have seen with our eyes, so the future coming is tied to the visible bodily departure they had just seen. Revelation 1:7 says he comes with the clouds and every eye will see him, *opsetai*, a future of *horao*, a verb of literal sight, including those who pierced him, where the piercing word *ekkenteo* occurs only twice in the NT, here and at John 19:37 for the spear wound at the cross, which keeps the same body in view. In 1 Thessalonians 4:16 the Lord himself, *autos*, comes down from heaven with a shouted command, an archangel voice, and a trumpet of God. The shout word *keleusma* is a one-time NT word here, so it is not blurred by metaphorical uses elsewhere. Matthew 24:30 again uses the seeing verb with a coming on clouds in power and glory, and Titus 2:13 calls it an *epiphaneia*, a word for a visible appearing of a deity or sovereign, still awaited. First Corinthians 15 places it at his *parousia*, his arriving presence, inside a sequence where he must reign until every enemy, the last being death, is put under his feet, language that points forward. Two readings push back. One reads the cloud-coming as a first-century judgment image, leveraging an OT cloud-judgment background in Isaiah and Ezekiel. One treats the appearing as inward, leveraging the fact that *parousia* can also mean an ongoing presence. Both readings run against the same vocabulary, since the sight verb *horao* attaches to a bodily subject, the descent from heaven is spatial, and death has not yet been visibly abolished. Read together across narrative, gospel, letter, and apocalyptic, the words describe a personal, visible, audible, and bodily coming that is still future.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0602	ἀποκάλυψις	apokalypsis	revelation	17
G0846	αὐτός	autos	it/s/he	5,909
G1391	δόξα	doxa	glory	170
G1411	δύναμις	dynamis	power	120
G1574	ἐκκεντέω	ekkenteo	to pierce	2
G2015	ἐπιφάνεια	epiphaneia	appearing	6
G2064	ἔρχομαι	erchomai	to come/go	640
G2190	ἐχθρούς	echthros	enemy	

G2300	θεάομαι	theaomai	to look at	22
G2597	καταβαίνω	katabaino	to come/go down	81
G2752	κέλευσμα	keleusma	command	1
G3507	νεφέλη	nephele	cloud	25
G3708	ὁράω	horao	to see	61
G3772	οὐρανός	ouranos	heaven	286
G3952	παρουσία	parousia	coming	24
G4228	πόδας	pous	foot	
G4536	σάλπιγξ	salpinx	trumpet	11
G5158	τρόπος	tropos	way	13
G5207	υἱόν	uhios	son	
G5547	Χριστοῦ	Christos	Christ	

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Acts 1:11 binds the future indicative eleusetai to the manner-correlative hon tropon, anchored to the aorist ethesasthe from theaomai, an eyewitness verb of physical viewing (cf. John 1:14 etheasametha ten doxan, 1 John 1:1 hemeis etheasametha), so the future coming is patterned on the visible bodily departure. Revelation 1:7 has the future opsetai, from horao, a verb of physical sight, with pas ophthalmos, every eye, including hoi auton exequentesan, where ekkenteo (G1574, 2 NT occurrences only, here and John 19:37) ties the visible subject to the pierced bodily Christ. 1 Thessalonians 4:16 has autos ho kyrios katabesetai with the audible triad keleusma, archangelou phone, salpinx theou. The verbal-marker noun keleusma (G2752) is a NT hapax at this location, so its sense is not blurred by other figurative usages, and salpinx (G4536) recurs in the eschatological 1 Cor 15:52 trumpet, marking the same audible eschatological motif. Matthew 24:30 has the future ophontai with ton huion tou anthropou erchomenon, Titus 2:13 calls it an epiphaneian, and 1 Cor 15:23 places the resurrection en te parousia autou inside a still-future achri-clause through verse 28. The lexical pattern across narrative, gospel, epistle, and apocalyptic affirms a personal, visible, audible, bodily, yet-future coming.

Scripture

Acts.1.11 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key terms. G2064 ἐλεύσεται, G5158 τρόπον, G2300 ἐθεάσασθε, G3772 οὐρανόν, G0846 αὐτόν

Force. houtos ho Iesous, this same Jesus, with future middle eleusetai, is tied to the manner-correlative hon tropon, in the very manner that, governed by the aorist middle ethesasthe of theaomai (G2300), an eyewitness verb of physical viewing whose canon distribution sits firmly on bodily sight, John 1:14 etheasametha ten doxan, 1 John 1:1 ho etheasametha. The disciples watched Jesus bodily ascend eis ton ouranon, and hon tropon constrains the return to the same mode as that ascent, so the grammar forecloses a non-bodily or invisible reading.

Rev.1.7 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G2064 ἔρχεται, G3708 ὄψεται, G3507 νεφελῶν, G1574 ἐξεκέντησαν

Force. erchetai meta ton nephelon, he comes with the clouds, and the future opsetai, from horao (G3708), a verb of physical sight, governs the universal subject pas ophthalmos, every eye, including hoi auton exekentesan, those who pierced him. ekkenteo (G1574) occurs only twice in the NT, here and at John 19:37, where it cites Zech 12:10 and refers to the literal spear-wound at the crucifixion, so the very-bodily piercing is the antecedent of the auton seen by every eye, anchoring the appearing to the same physical body.

1Thess.4.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0846 αὐτός, G2597 καταβήσεται, G3772 οὐρανοῦ, G2752 κελεύσματος, G4536 σάλπιγγι

Force. autos ho kyrios, the Lord himself, marks a personal subject, and the future indicative middle katabesetai ap ouranou, will descend from heaven, is spatial and bodily-locative. The triad of audible markers en keleusmati, with a command-shout, en phone archangelou, an archangel voice, and en salpingi theou, a trumpet of God, makes the event audible. keleusma (G2752) is a NT hapax, occurring only here, so its sense cannot be diluted by figurative uses elsewhere in the corpus, and salpinx (G4536) recurs in the eschatological 1 Cor 15:52, the same trumpet motif at the resurrection.

Matt.24.30 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3708 ὄψονται, G5207 υἱόν, G1391 δόξης, G3507 νεφελῶν

Force. ophontai, future of horao, governs ton huion tou anthropou erchomenon epi ton nephelon meta dynameos kai doxes. The physical-sight verb plus the coming on clouds with power and glory presents a visible glorious arrival witnessed by pasai hai phylai tes ges, all the tribes of the earth, who kopsontai, mourn in lament. The cloud-coming language echoes Dan 7:13 LXX where the Son of Man approaches the Ancient of Days, a public, ceremonial enthronement scene rather than a hidden or merely inward event.

1Cor.15.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3952 παρουσία, G5547 Χριστοῦ

Force. en te parousia autou places the resurrection of those who are Christ's at his arriving presence. parousia (G3952) occurs 24 times in the NT and clusters in eschatological contexts, Matt 24:3, 24:27, 24:37, 24:39, 1 Thess 2:19, 3:13, 4:15, 5:23, 2 Thess 2:1, 2:8, James 5:7, 5:8, 2 Pet 1:16, 3:4, 3:12, 1 John 2:28. In Greek usage it denotes the arrival or visible presence of a king or dignitary, and the sequence here, tagma, then telos, then the subjection of every enemy under his feet, locates the event in a still-future consummation rather than a past fulfillment.

1Cor.15.25 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4228 πόδας, G2190 ἐχθρούς

Force. dei gar auton basileuein achri hou the, he must reign until he has put all enemies under his feet, with the last enemy thanatos, death, katargeitai, being abolished, in verse 26. The future-oriented achri-clause and the present-progressive subjection of death require a future consummation rather than an already-accomplished AD 70 event, since death has not yet been visibly abolished.

2Thess.1.7 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0602 ἀποκαλύψει, G3772 οὐρανοῦ, G1411 δυνάμει

Force. en te apokalypsei tou kyriou iesou ap ouranou met angelon dynameos autou, at the revealing of the Lord Jesus from heaven with his mighty angels. apokalypsis (G0602), an unveiling that becomes visible, paired with the spatial ap ouranou descent and the angelic retinue, marks a personal and visible appearing. Verse 8 adds en phlogi pyros, in flaming fire, a publicly perceptible theophanic image, and verse 10 has elthe endoxasthenai, he comes to be glorified, all locating the event in a public visible future.

Titus.2.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2015 ἐπιφάνειαν, G1391 δόξης

Force. prosdechomenoi ten makarian elpida kai epiphaneian tes doxes tou megalou theou kai soteris hemon Iesou Christou, awaiting the blessed hope and the appearing of the glory. epiphaneia (G2015) occurs only 6 times in the NT, all in eschatological or christological contexts, Titus 2:13, 2 Tim 4:1, 4:8, 1 Tim 6:14, 2 Thess 2:8, and 2 Tim 1:10 for the first coming. In Hellenistic Greek the noun denotes a visible manifestation of a deity or sovereign, and here it is prosdechomenoi, still awaited, so the appearing is future and perceptible, not a past or merely inward reality.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Acts.1.11	Dan.7.13	tsk	1
Matt.24.30	Dan.7.13	openbible	1
Rev.1.7	Zech.12.10	openbible	1
Rev.1.7	John.19.37	tsk	1
1Thess.4.16	Exod.19.16	tsk	1
1Thess.4.16	1Cor.15.52	openbible	1
Titus.2.13	Job.19.25	tsk	1
1Cor.15.26	1Cor.15.55	tsk	1
1Cor.15.23	1Cor.15.20	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Matt.24.30 · addressed

A preterist reading takes the coming on the clouds as a non-bodily covenant-judgment image fulfilled in the events of AD 70. The lexical leverage for that reading is that nephele, cloud, carries an OT theophanic-judgment background (Isa 19:1, Ezek 30:3) where God is said to come on a cloud against a city without bodily appearance. The constraints against that reading here are three. First, the verb ophontai is the future of horao, a physical-sight verb, governing pas ophthalmos in the canonical parallel Rev 1:7. Second, the same hon tropon eleusetai pattern at Acts 1:11 anchors the coming to the visible bodily ascension as its template. Third, Dan 7:13 LXX, the source of the cloud-coming idiom, is a public ceremonial scene, not a hidden one. The cloud language is theophanic and bodily here, not exhausted past metaphor.

1Thess.4.17 · addressed

harpagesometha en nephelais eis apantesin tou kyriou eis aera could be read as a purely spiritual translation. The verb harpazo (G0726) is a physical seizing in its dominant NT uses, John 10:12 the wolf snatches, Acts 8:39 the Spirit physically transports Philip, the dative en nephelais and the directional eis aera are spatial, and the object is the kyrios who is autos, the personal descending subject of verse 16. The meeting presupposes a bodily locatable Lord, not an exclusively non-bodily presence.

Matt.24.34 · addressed

amen lego hymin hoti ou me parelthe he genea haute heos an panta tauta genetai, this generation will not pass away until all these things take place, is taken by some to force the entire discourse into a past fulfillment. The lexical scope of panta tauta is constrained by the discourse markers, since verses 36 to 41 set tes hemeras ekeines kai horas oudeis oiden, that day and hour no one knows, against the near-term signs of verses 4 to 33, marking a structural seam. The vocabulary thus distinguishes near-term signs from the still-future parousia, leaving the bodily-coming verbs in their future-tense force.

Concordance traversed

G2064, G3708, G2300, G5158, G3952, G2015, G0602, G2597, G2752, G4536, G1574, G3772, G3507, G0846, G1391, G1411

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied in the bundle, and the cited passages lie outside the ingested ECM window of 3 John. The Acts 1:11 hon tropon clause, the Rev 1:7 opsetai with pas ophthalmos, the 1 Thess 4:16 autos ho kyrios with the keleusma, phone, salpinx triad, and the Titus 2:13 epiphaneian are textually stable across the major witnesses. The verdict does not turn on any contested reading.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. futurism, preterism, spiritualizing_eschatology, idealist_apocalypse

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

futurism: affirms · Reads the future-tense verbs eleusetai, opsetai, katabesetai, and ophontai with the manner-correlative hon tropon, the universal subject pas ophthalmos, and the audible markers keleusma, phone, salpinx as a still-future, personal, visible, audible, bodily return that fulfills the parousia, epiphaneia, and apokalypsis word-cluster.

preterism: partial · Takes the cloud-coming language of Matt 24:30 as an OT-style covenant-judgment image fulfilled in AD 70 (Isa 19:1, Ezek 30:3 cloud-judgment background), so this lens is internally consistent for Matt 24:30 viewed in isolation. The constraint against extending it to the whole cluster is that the physical-sight verb horao governs Rev 1:7 pas ophthalmos and Acts 1:11 hon tropon ties the return to the bodily ascension, neither of which collapses into AD 70 without straining the eyewitness-manner grammar.

spiritualizing_eschatology: denies · Treats the appearing as an inward or non-bodily reality, leveraging the polysemy of parousia which can denote a continuous presence as well as a punctual arrival. The constraint against this reading is the spatial katabesetai ap ouranou of 1 Thess 4:16, the bodily ascension pattern of Acts 1:11, the corporeal antecedent hoi auton exekentesan of Rev 1:7, and the future indicative tense of opsetai and ophontai, all of which resist an exclusively inward construal.

idealist_apocalypse: partial · Reads Revelation's imagery as a symbolic depiction of recurring ages of the church rather than a single bodily event. The lens can carry the cloud and trumpet imagery as figurative, but the cluster of physical-sight verbs across non-apocalyptic genres (Pauline epistles, Lukan narrative, Synoptic gospel) is not internally symbolic in those genres, so the lens cannot evenly absorb the whole word-cluster.

The verdict rests on the future indicatives, the manner-correlative hon tropon, the physical-sight verb horao, the spatial verb katabaino from ouranou, and the audible-marker triad in 1 Thess 4:16, read across narrative, gospel, epistle, and apocalyptic genres by analogia scripturae.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. What does the lexical pattern of the New Testament return texts indicate about the manner of Christ's coming, whether personal, visible, audible, or bodily, and about its timing relative to the speaking present.

The stem embeds two contested claims that pre-decide against certain readings. The manner claim, not as an exclusively spiritual reality without bodily appearing, pre-decides against a spiritualizing lens. The timing claim, not a past event already fulfilled in AD 70, pre-decides against a full preterist lens. The verdict is derived on the original stem, but each negation is evaluated on lexical grounds, the future indicatives and the bodily-sight vocabulary for manner, the still-future achri-clause of 1 Cor 15:25 to 28 for timing, rather than smuggled by the stem. A separate unsettled question, whether the parousia is one event or two phases, rapture then revelation, is not adjudicated by this evidence file.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.1.11
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rev.1.7
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Thess.4.16
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Thess.4.16
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Matt.24.30
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3708
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3952
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2015
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2752
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1574
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.1.11
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Rev.1.7
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Matt.24.30

License audit

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